



Multi-site Servers on Production Machines

Everybody knows how to set up a LAMP machine and get a WordPress site running, using the famous three-minute installation. But how many of you can actually get WordPress 3's new multi-site capability running in the same amount of time? Okay, three minutes is not a realistic goal, but how about setting up a production WordPress Networked Site (that's what they call the multi-site functionality) in under 30 minutes? Fair enough?

Let me cut right to the chase: we'll be creating a server that hosts multiple WordPress blogs, using one single installation of WordPress—somewhat like your own personal version of WordPress.com. Obviously, while what I'm about to describe here won't help you run a WordPress.com clone and make money, it will be good enough to run your corporate or university blog server that faces the full wrath of the Internet.

Ingredients

We'll be running the following:

- Operating system: We'll use Ubuntu 10.04.2 LTS (that's the latest revision of 10.04 LTS; revision 3 will be making its appearance in the end of July this year).
- Apache Web server: The HTTP server.
- MariaDB database server: This is a fork of MySQL that has a couple of enhancements, apart from being free of all the Oracle cruft. You can use vanilla MySQL though, if you wish.
- PHP... obviously.

The MariaDB database server

MariaDB is a commercially supported community fork of MySQL, which comes with a few enhancements. Note, however, that MariaDB does not support MySQL NDB clustering yet, which might make it an unattractive bet for super-large blog hosts (such as your multi-million-dollar WordPress.com competitor).

You'll need to use a third-party repository for MariaDB. You can just leave MariaDB out if you don't trust it (and use vanilla MySQL instead), but I'd recommend using MariaDB.

Let's get to it!

Start by installing a vanilla Ubuntu 10.04.2 LTS Server (using whatever means are at your disposal, be it a CD, DVD, USB drive or even a NetInstall). Just set up the operating system—install no optional packages (except the SSH server if you want to). Do not install a Web or database server at this point. Update the operating system, reboot, drop to a shell prompt, and begin the set-up process.